Ask Agent 001

A Basic Digicam

Q I plan to buy a digital camera in the range of Rs 6K to 8K. I am a casual shutterbug—all I am looking at is a decent point-and-shoot camera. Good picture clarity, reasonable amount of storage memory and compact size are the more important considerations. Also, I'd like to go for a known brand.

Kiran

There are many good digicams in the price range you're looking at. Depending on the features, the price will vary between Rs 8.5K and 10K. Canon's PowerShot A310 and A400 are retail at around Rs 9K, while Nikon Coolpix 3100 and Kodak EasyShare CX7220 are available at around Rs 8.5K. On the features front, Canon's A400 leads the pack with a 3.2 megapixel (MP) sensor, while the rest have a 2 MP sensor. However, when making a buying decision, you should also take into account after-sales service, as these digital cameras tend to turn into photogenic paperweights if they develop problems. Find out which of the above-mentioned companies have a good network in your city.

An AMD Gaming Rig

Q I want to build an AMD-based gaming rig. Initially, I thought of getting an AMD Athlon FX 53, but I could not find a retailer selling it, nor was I able to get hold of the FX 51. Also, on the Athlon 64 side, only the 3500+ is available at the top end. Which is the right one for me? Since you always advise good power supplies, I want to install a 400W Antec or VIP. Is that a fair choice? Also, is the iBall cabinet with its own SMPS good, or should I go for one of the above? Which memory should I opt for? Hynix, Kingston...?

Mohith

Top-end AMD processors are hard to find in the retail market. If you want to buy any of them, you will need to contact AMD's main distributor in India, Tech Pacific, on 022-55960101. You can also write to pratik.chube@techpacindia.com for more information on AMD processors.

As for the SMPS, although the iBall cabinets offer a power supply like all other case manufacturers do, they hardly match up to the performance and reliability offered by Antec or VIP. If I had to buy one, I would bet my money on Antec.

Buy memory modules from any vendor—just make sure they are genuine and compatible with your motherboard.

Gimme The Graphics—Price No Bar

Q I want to buy a graphics card. I have a Pentium 4 processor plugged onto a 915-chipset motherboard. Which graphics card can play all the games (well, almost all) available in the market, and also forthcoming titles such as *Quake 4* and the like? Money is not an issue.

Vedamurthy Rajarajan

Cards based on nVidia's 6800 Ultra chipset offer the best performance, albeit at a significant price. So, if you want the best of the best graphics cards, go for a card based on the 6800 Ultra chipset from vendors such as Gainward, MSI or Asus, and expect to pay around Rs 40K. With this card in your system, you can play any game with all the eye candy on, and, at resolutions as high as 1600 x 1200.

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Hot In Hyderabad

Q I have a computer with a 2.8 GHz HT-enabled Pentium 4 processor. After a few months of use, I've noticed that the system gets hotter as I play games or run it for few hours. Once the system gets hot, the fans whirl faster, emitting a loud noise.

After some research on the Internet, I found that using a good thermal compound helps a lot. Arctic Silver seems to be the best thermal compound, but I am unable to locate it in Hyderabad. Can you help in locating a dealer?

Naveen

The new Pentium processors based on the Prescott core generally tend to run hotter, and hence, if you have one, your system *will* run hot. The heating is nothing to worry about; however, the resulting noise from the fans can be irritating. Good thermal compounds do reduce temperatures, but don't expect miracles. Your computer's temperature will go down by about 4 to 5 degrees at best. Still, if you want to give it a try, you can call G Bhatia from Prime ABGB Pvt Ltd on 022-23896600.

Of RAM Latencies

Q I have an AMD Athlon XP 2400+ CPU on an Asus A7N8X-Deluxe board. I want to buy 512 MB of DDR 400 MHz TwinX memory modules from Corsair. Four types of TwinX are available, out of which the XL and XLPT have the lowest latency, LL is of low latency and the regualar TwinX is of normal latency.

What is latency? Should I buy RAM of higher or lower latency? What RAM module should I buy to get the maximum performance from my system?

Shujat Ali

All computer components have some amount of latency, i.e., the time required to react after it receives a signal to send or receive data. When the CPU requires some data stored in RAM, it takes some time for the data to reach the processor due to the latency of the memory module. Hence, if your memory modules have low latency, they will transmit data faster, which translates into better performance. The TwinX XL, XLPT and LL all have extremely low latencies compared to regular memory modules, so they deliver better performance. A set of 256 MB TwinX LL modules will set you back by Rs 9.8K, and the price tag increases as the latencies drop. I would suggest you go for the regular TwinX memory module as they are more than enough for your requirements. ⊠

Ask Away

Want a tech product, but don't know how to go about buying it? Send an e-mail to **agent001@thinkdigit.com** to get your queries answered